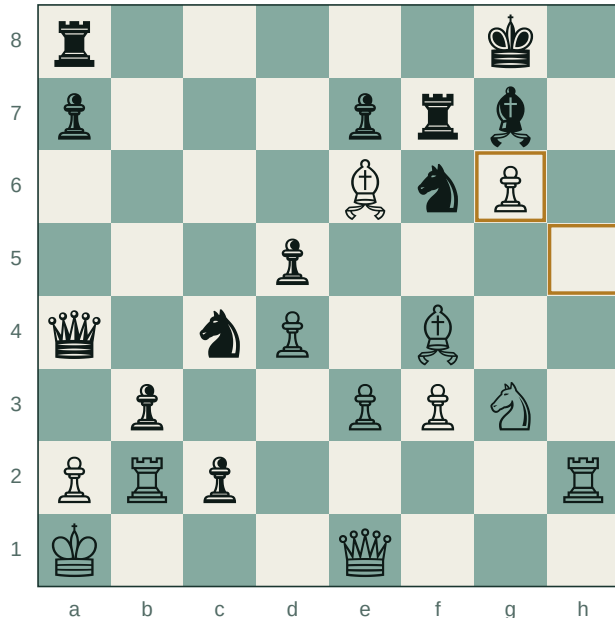


Calculated sacrifices: Black, move 26

Calculated sacrifices

Black to move



Previous move: 26.hxg6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Nxg6 27. gxf7+ Kf8 28. Kxg6 Qxa2+

26...Nxg6 The knight captures the rook on b2. Recorded reply: **27.gxf7+**.

27...Kf8 The king moves from g8 to f8. Recorded reply: **28.Kxg6**.

28...Qxa2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on a2.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by -2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -2: the balance goes from +0 to -2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attractive attacking picture is not compensation by itself. Continue until the resulting position can be evaluated honestly.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A sacrifice exchanges material for a concrete benefit. The benefit may be mate, a stronger attack, a recovered investment, or lasting activity; it must be shown through moves.

HOW TO LOOK

State what the sacrifice changes: a defender, a line, a king square, or a critical tempo. Calculate acceptance and plausible refusal.

The defending king is on a1. Absolute pin: pawn on a2.